

FIELD NOTES FROM TRAVEL

THE STUFF THEY HOPE YOU NEVER FIGURE OUT



PATRICIA SIMMONS PRESENTS

The Insider Travel *Playbook*

*Twenty years in travel, distilled into the plays that save you money
and get you through the airport like a pro.*

PATRICIA SIMMONS

TRAVEL INSIDER, 20 YRS



A TRAVELER'S FIELD GUIDE

Patricia's Insider Travel Playbook

*Ten things the airlines and the airports quietly count
on you never noticing. Read them once. Use them
forever.*

A word from *the inside.*

I've worked in travel for twenty years, and I've watched a few million people move through airports. The honeymooners, the business folks who think the rules don't apply to them, the families running for a gate they already missed. The one thing almost every one of them has in common is this: they're leaving money on the table, and they have no idea.

I'm not talking about complicated finance tricks. I'm talking about the quiet stuff the airlines and the airports count on you never noticing. The fare that drops after you buy. The refund nobody tells you to ask for. The protection you already paid for and never used.

So I wrote it all down. Ten insider plays, plain and simple, the way I'd tell my own niece before she flies. None of it's complicated. All of it works. Let's get into it.

Patricia

PATRICIA SIMMONS · TRAVEL INSIDER

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PART ONE

Money back *after you book.*

The booking is not the finish line. The biggest savings happen after you've already paid, and almost nobody goes back to collect them.

01 · PRICE DROPS

02 · REFUNDS

03 · COVERAGE

01

The price drop *nobody tells you about*

Here's something that'll bother you for the rest of your traveling life once you know it. The price of your flight or your hotel keeps moving after you've already booked it. It goes up, it goes down, all day long. When it drops below what you paid, the airline doesn't call you up and offer you the difference. They just keep it.

Most folks book their trip and never look at the price again, because why would you? It feels done. That's exactly what they're counting on.

☐ WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Book a fare or a room that's changeable or refundable, even if it costs a few dollars more, because that's what lets you act when the price moves. Take a screenshot of what you paid. Then watch that same flight and same room in the days after you book. If the price drops and your fare allows a change, you rebook at the lower rate and pocket the difference. There are tools that watch the price for you around the clock, which is honestly the smart way, because nobody's got time to check fares at two in the morning. The one I use is Repriced.ai. You connect your email so it finds your bookings and add your card so it can actually lock in the savings, then it watches the price day and night and rebooks you automatically when it drops, putting the difference back in your pocket.

“*The airline isn't going to call you when the price drops. So you've got to be the one watching.*”

02

The refund the airline *owes you*

Twenty years I've watched people stand at a gate, flight cancelled, just accepting a voucher like it's a gift. That voucher is not a gift. In a lot of cases you are owed your actual money back, in cash, not credit.

When an airline cancels your flight, you're generally entitled to a full refund to your original payment, even on a nonrefundable ticket, if you choose not to fly the rebooked option. Same goes for big schedule changes and long delays. Delayed bags, getting bumped from an oversold flight, a service you paid for and never got, all of that can come back to you.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Don't accept the first voucher they wave at you. Ask, out loud and politely, for a refund to your original form of payment. Keep every boarding pass, every delay notice, every receipt. If they delay or lose your bag, file the claim in writing before you leave the airport. The money is sitting there. You just have to be the one person at the gate who actually asks for it.

“ *A voucher keeps your money inside their building. A refund puts it back in your pocket. Know the difference.* ”

03

Coverage you
already paid for

This one makes me shake my head every time. People stand at the kiosk buying travel insurance, trip protection, rental coverage, the whole menu, and a good number of them already have most of it sitting in their wallet.

A lot of travel credit cards come with protections built right in when you pay for the trip with that card. Trip delay reimbursement that buys you a meal and a hotel when you're stuck. Lost or delayed baggage coverage. Rental car collision coverage that lets you wave off the pushy counter upsell. Some even cover trip cancellation.

 WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Before you ever pay for extra coverage, pull up your card's benefits guide, the real one, and read what you already have. Then use the card that carries the best protection to book the trip, because the coverage usually only kicks in if you paid with that card. That rental counter person pushing the daily insurance? If your card already covers it, you smile and say no thank you. Stop buying twice what you already own.

“*Read your card benefits once. You're probably carrying insurance you've paid for and never touched.*”

PART TWO

The smart way *to book it.*

Half of what people overpay happens before they ever get to the airport. The fare, the bag, the seat, the search itself. Here's how to do all of it right.

04 · TIMING

05 · BAGS

06 · SEATS

07 · LOUNGES

04

When to actually book *(and the myth that won't die)*

Everybody's got an uncle who swears flights are cheapest at midnight on a Tuesday. I've heard it for twenty years. It's mostly nonsense. There's no magic clock. What actually moves the price is how far ahead you book and how busy the route is.

For most domestic trips, the sweet spot is roughly one to three months out. For international, look further, more like two to eight months ahead. Book too early and you often overpay. Wait until the last two weeks and the airline knows it's got you, so the price climbs.

☐ WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Start watching your route early, but don't panic-buy the first fare you see. Set a fare alert so the price comes to you instead of you chasing it. Stay flexible on your days, because flying a day on either side of the weekend can save real money. And remember the cheapest seat isn't always the best deal once you add bags and seats, so look at the full price before you celebrate.

“*There's no secret hour when fares get cheap. There's a smart window. Learn it.*”

05

Beat the bag fees

I see it all day long. Folks dragging a carry-on the size of a small refrigerator, then acting shocked at the gate when they get hit with a fee. Bag fees are where airlines make a fortune, and they design the whole thing hoping you'll trip over the rules.

 WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Know your airline's exact carry-on and personal-item sizes before you pack, and actually use that personal item. A good backpack that slides under the seat in front of you holds a shocking amount, and on a lot of fares it's free. If you're checking a bag, prepay it online, because checking at the counter almost always costs more. Weigh your bag at home with a cheap luggage scale so you're not repacking your underwear on the floor in front of everybody. And wear your heaviest shoes and jacket through the airport instead of packing them. None of it's glamorous. All of it keeps your money where it belongs.

“ *The bag fee isn't an accident. It's a business model. Pack like you know that.*

06

Free seats and the *upgrade game*

Airlines have gotten very good at making you feel like you have to pay to sit down. You book your ticket, and suddenly every decent seat costs extra. Here's the truth from someone who watches boarding every day: a lot of those fees are optional, and a lot of people pay them out of fear.

☐ WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

If you don't care exactly where you sit, you can often skip the seat fee and let the airline assign you one for free at check-in. Traveling with family? Many airlines are now required to seat young kids next to a parent at no charge, so don't let them scare you into paying. Check in the moment the window opens, because seats open up as the flight fills. Want a real shot at the front? Join the free frequent flyer program, because members get upgrade priority over the person who never signed up. And if the flight looks empty, wait and grab a whole empty row after boarding.

“ *Half the seat fees people pay are just fear with a price tag on it.* ”

07

Lounge comfort *without the status*

People walk past those lounge doors like they're velvet rope at a club, figuring it's only for first class and big shots. It's not. There are more ways through that door than most travelers ever realize.

☐ WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Check your credit card first, because a lot of travel cards include lounge access or a set number of passes every year, and people forget it's even there. If you don't have that, you can often buy a single day pass, and on a long layover a few quiet hours with free food, real coffee, clean bathrooms, and decent wifi can be worth every penny instead of buying that same food piece by piece at gate prices. Some lounges even let you in free if your flight's delayed long enough, so ask. And if the lounge isn't in the cards, find the quiet end of the terminal near the higher gate numbers, where the crowds thin out and the outlets are free.

“*The lounge isn't a club for big shots. It's a door, and there are more keys to it than they let on.*”

III

PART THREE

Once you're *in my house.*

The terminal is built to separate you from your money and your time. I've watched it work for twenty years. Here's how you walk through it like you own the place.

08 · THE LINE

09 · MARKUP

10 · SEARCHING

08

Get through security *faster than everybody*

I've stood in a thousand of these lines and watched them back up the same way every time. Most of the holdup at security isn't the machines. It's people who get to the front with no idea what's about to happen. So let me save you the wait.

☐ WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Have your ID and boarding pass out before you reach the front, not buried in a bag. Empty your pockets into your own bag before you're at the front, not into the bin where small things vanish. Take your liquids and laptop out ahead of time unless you're in a trusted-traveler lane that says you don't have to. Wear shoes you can slip off and back on, and skip the belt with the giant buckle and the pockets full of change. If you fly more than a couple times a year, an expedited screening membership pays for itself fast. Move with a plan and you're through in half the time.

“*The line isn't slow because of the machines. It's slow because folks show up with no plan. Have a plan.*”

09 Dodge the *airport markup*

Seven dollars for a bottle of water. Eighteen for a sad little sandwich. I've watched airport prices climb for twenty years, and they climb because they know you're trapped in there with nowhere else to go. That's the whole game. They've got a captive audience and they price like it.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Bring an empty water bottle through security, completely empty so it's allowed, and fill it at the fountains or bottle-filling stations on the other side for free. Pack your own snacks from home, because a granola bar in your bag costs a quarter of what it costs at the gate. If you do buy food, walk a little past the first shops by your gate, since the spots tucked deeper in the terminal are often cheaper than the ones banking on you being rushed. And skip the duty-free "deal" unless you've checked the price at home first, because plenty of it isn't the bargain the big shiny sign wants you to believe.

“ *They price that seven-dollar water knowing you can't leave. The empty bottle in your bag is how you win that one.* ”

10

Search smarter *and*
pay less

The way you search for a trip changes the price you see, and most people search in the one way that costs them the most. They punch in a round trip on the first site they think of, take the number it gives them, and never question it.

☐ WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Compare a few sites before you commit, and always check the airline's own website too, because the price is sometimes lower there and the change rules are almost always friendlier than a third-party booking. Price your round trip, then price it as two one-way tickets, because now and then two one-ways on different airlines beat the round trip outright. Look at the nearby airport if your city has one, since a short drive can mean a much cheaper fare. And weigh that bargain connecting flight honestly, because a brutal layover that risks your bag and your sanity isn't a deal, it's a trap with a discount.

“*The first price you see is rarely the best one. It's just the one they're hoping you'll take.*”

The Pre-Flight Checklist TEAR-OUT

All ten plays, boiled down to what you actually do. Run through it before your next trip.

AFTER YOU BOOK

- ☐ Book changeable or refundable fares so you can act when the price moves.
- ☐ Screenshot what you paid, then keep watching the same flight and room.
- ☐ Rebook when it drops below what you paid, and pocket the difference.
- ☐ When they cancel, ask for a cash refund to your card, not a voucher.
- ☐ File any delayed or lost bag claim in writing before you leave the airport.
- ☐ Read your card benefits and skip insurance you already carry.

BOOKING SMART

- ☐ Book domestic one to three months out, international two to eight.
- ☐ Set a fare alert instead of chasing the price yourself.
- ☐ Use your free personal item, and prepay any checked bag online.
- ☐ Weigh your bag at home and wear your heaviest shoes and jacket.
- ☐ Skip seat fees, check in the minute it opens, join the free loyalty program.
- ☐ Check your card for lounge access before you pay for a pass.

AT THE AIRPORT

- ☐ ID and boarding pass out and ready before you reach the checkpoint.
- ☐ Liquids and laptop staged before the front of the line.
- ☐ Empty bottle through security, then refill it free on the other side.
- ☐ Pack your own snacks and walk past the first overpriced shops.
- ☐ Compare sites, check the airline direct, and price two one-ways too.

“

Use one, save something. Use all of them, and you'll never travel the old way again.

ONE LAST THING

Now *you* notice.

There it is. Twenty years of watching people travel the hard way, boiled down to ten things you can actually use. None of it's complicated. All of it works.

The airlines and the airports built a system that quietly counts on you being too busy, too rushed, or too trusting to notice. You don't have to use all ten at once. Start with number one, because the price drop after you book is the one almost nobody catches, and it's real money. If you'd rather have that one watched and caught for you automatically, that's exactly what Repriced.ai was built to do. Then work down the list on your next trip.

Use one, save something, and you'll never travel the old way again. Safe travels. And next time you're at the airport, have your boarding pass ready.

Patricia

PATRICIA SIMMONS · TRAVEL INSIDER, 20 YEARS



*“I’m not judging you. I’m just
telling you.”*

PATRICIA SIMMONS

TRAVEL INSIDER · TWENTY YEARS IN TRAVEL

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